



LIONS LIGHT ACADEMY

Teacher & Mentor Guidebook

*A companion for teaching, mentoring, and keeping a room where
wonder is possible*

*"It is the glory of God to conceal a matter, but the glory of kings is to
search it out."*

PROVERBS 25:2

EFFECTIVE

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1. Welcome & Purpose

Welcome to Lions Light Academy, a community where education becomes worship — a joyful pursuit of wisdom in God's creation.

As a teacher or mentor, you play a vital role in shaping not only minds, but hearts and faith.

This guidebook is designed to help you lead with confidence, creativity, and peace. It serves as your companion for planning lessons, building relationships, and fostering an atmosphere of curiosity and Christ-centered learning.

"Teaching is lighting the way — not with answers, but with the courage to search."

2. Our Vision

We see Lions Light Academy as a Christ-inspired seed — a space where wonder and worship intertwine. Every child carries a spark of curiosity, waiting to ignite into wisdom and purpose.

We hold fast to the truth that all creation reflects the Creator. Every discovery, every question, and every new idea becomes an act of worship.

Core Values: Christ-Centered • Curiosity • Community • Creativity • Stewardship

3. The Role of the Teacher

Teaching at Lions Light is not about control, but cultivation. You are called to guide exploration, spark curiosity, and nurture faith.

Cultivation still requires a well-kept garden. The order you keep in your room is what makes exploration possible, and keeping it is part of the calling, not a departure from it. Section 8 covers what that looks like in practice.

A Lions Light Teacher leads with humility, invites questions without fear, models curiosity and grace, and encourages both academic and spiritual growth.

"The goal is not to fill a mind, but to awaken a heart."

Reflection Prompt: How can I create moments where my students experience awe, not just information?

4. Teaching Philosophy

Our educational model is mentor-guided, experiential, and faith-rooted. We believe students learn best when they explore real-world connections — not through memorization, but through meaning.

Guiding Principles: Experience First • Ask, Don't Tell • Faith Woven In • Whole Child Focus

Example: Instead of telling students how plants grow, let them plant seeds, observe light and water, and marvel at God's design through discovery.

5. Excellence & High Expectations

Every student here is capable of more than they think. Calling that out of them is part of your work.

Excellence at Lions Light is not perfectionism, and it is not competition. We do not rank children against each other. We ask each student to bring their whole effort to what is in front of them, because the work itself is an offering. A student's best is measured against their own ceiling, never against the child beside them.

"Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord." — Colossians 3:23

What pushing a student looks like here: Expect more than the minimum • Name their potential out loud • Let them struggle before you rescue them • Ask for the revision • Praise the effort and the growth, not only the result • Hold the standard warmly, and hold it every time

What it does not look like: Shaming a student who falls short • Comparing one child to another • Pushing past a child's real limit • Mistaking intensity for high standards

Consistency is the whole thing. A standard that moves depending on your mood teaches students to read you instead of reaching. A standard that holds steady teaches them what they are capable of.

A student should leave your class knowing you believed they could do hard things. That belief, held steadily over a year, does more than pressure ever will.

"We love our students enough to challenge them — and we challenge them because we love them."

Reflection Prompt: Did I ask my students for their best today, or did I accept what was easiest to accept?

6. Conduct & Professional Expectations

Teachers are the heartbeat of our academy's culture. You represent the light, grace, and excellence of Lions Light in every moment.

Expectations: Be punctual, prepared, and prayerful • Communicate with kindness • Build unity through encouragement • Approach correction as restoration, not punishment • Model humility and forgiveness

7. Creating a Christ-Centered Classroom

Your classroom should feel like a living extension of God's peace — a place where students feel safe to wonder, question, and grow.

Ways to Build That Space: Begin each class with prayer • Integrate Scripture naturally • Encourage gratitude journaling • Handle disruptions with grace

Reflection Prompt: What would it look like if every student left my classroom feeling seen, valued, and closer to God?

8. Order, Authority & Correction

A classroom without order cannot do a single thing described in this guidebook. Wonder needs safety. Discovery needs attention. No student can search out a matter in a room that has gotten away from the adult in it.

So when we say teaching here is not about control, we mean something specific. We do not manage students for the sake of managing them. We keep order so that learning and worship are possible. Order serves the room. It is not the point of the room.

You have authority. Use it.

You are authorized to correct behavior immediately, and to remove a student from the class or activity temporarily when that is what the room needs. You do not need to ask permission first. You do not need to wait for leadership to arrive. Handle it, then document it and tell us.

Hesitating to correct is not gentleness. A room where students are unsure whether the adult will act is an anxious room, and anxious students do not explore.

How correction escalates

Our Escalation & Discipline Policy sorts behavior into three levels. In the room, it works like this:

Minor — a disruption, slow to follow instructions, a sharp tone, a phone out when it shouldn't be. *Correct it on the spot. Redirect, restate the expectation, keep going.* Minor concerns are not counted and not tracked.

Moderate — it keeps happening after correction, or there's disrespect toward an adult or a peer, or work the class depends on wasn't done two sessions running, or a student simply will not engage. *Pull the student aside, or out of the activity if you need to. Report it to leadership, who issue the warning and notify the family.* The first and second moderate concerns in a year each carry a warning. The third begins the Reconciliation Process.

Warnings count across the whole co-op, not per class, so a student's second warning might come from a teacher who's never corrected them before. You don't have to track that — leadership does.

Severe — anything unsafe, aggressive, or threatening, or defiance that puts the room at risk. *Remove immediately. Get leadership. Parents are called that day.* No warning at this level. One severe incident starts the Reconciliation Process.

Severity determines the immediate response. A severe incident never waits its turn behind a warning count, and repeated minor concerns never become severe by adding up. You may raise a pattern of minor concerns to Moderate, and no further.

Stepping a student out to finish work

If a student shows up without the work the lesson depends on, or falls behind partway through, you can send them to the hallway or lounge to finish and come back in when they're done.

Use this freely. It is not discipline. Nothing gets written down, nothing gets counted, and it should not carry any weight in how you speak to the student — you are protecting the lesson for the room, not

punishing anyone. Say it that way: *"go finish that, then come back in."*

They stay supervised, always. Whoever is in the main room has the hallway. The teachers lounge works only when an adult is already sitting in it — an empty lounge gets no student in it either. Never send a student somewhere no adult can see them.

When a student stops trying

Name it. That's your call to make.

Work not done **two sessions in a row** is a Moderate concern. Raise it. You don't need a month of evidence and you don't need to ask anyone first.

This is the part volunteers talk themselves out of. It feels ungracious to say a student isn't trying. But a class where nobody did the reading is a class you can't teach, and the students who did the reading are the ones paying for your reluctance. Naming it in week two is kinder than letting it run to June.

Say it plainly and without heat: *"this is the second week. What's going on?"* Sometimes that question is the whole intervention.

The call that belongs to you

You also decide when small disruptions have stopped being small. There's no magic number — three corrections in a morning is an ordinary day for one student and a real problem for another. You're in the room. You decide.

When you make that call, say it to the student at the time, and jot down what it was based on. Minor concerns aren't tracked, so the pattern lives only in your memory until you write it down. "He's been disruptive lately" is not something a family can respond to. Three specific moments is.

Grace is yours to give

Kids go through things. When you can see that something real is going on with a student, use your judgment and extend some room. You know them. That's why you're teaching them and not someone else.

Two things about that. It's your judgment, not their argument — the student who opens with *"I've had a hard week"* every week is telling you what the problem is, not giving you a reason. And grace means adjusting how you come at it, not lowering what you expect. The work still has to get done.

Where a student genuinely can't rather than won't, and it's beyond what you can absorb in your class, bring it to leadership. Don't carry it alone and don't let it quietly become a discipline matter.

What you don't decide

Restoration. That belongs to leadership.

You don't issue warnings, define repair, decide restoration, or decide whether a student stays. Report what happened and hand it up. Leadership carries that weight, which is how it should be — it protects you as much as the student.

The full policy governs, and it covers the escalation pathway, the Reconciliation Process, documentation, and continued participation. Read it once at the start of the year and keep it where you can find it. It is in the Resources library on the site.

Correction is restoration

We correct because we intend to keep the student, not because we are building a case against them. Once safety and order are secured, the aim is always to bring the student back in. Discipline here is corrective. It is never shaming.

Restoration is real at LLA, and it is offered to every student. It is also not free. A student who has done damage owns what happened, repairs it, and then meets the terms of a written plan across four co-op days they are present, with absences extending the period rather than counting toward it, before they are restored. An apology on its own doesn't finish it. We hold that line because a restoration that costs nothing teaches nothing.

What we're hoping for is more than compliance with a plan. We're hoping the student actually changes. But the plan is what they're measured against, and they sign it in advance, so no child's place here rests on whether an adult feels they've transformed enough.

When a student completes the process, their warning count goes back to zero. Treat them that way. A student who has been restored is restored, and carrying it forward in how you speak to them undoes the whole thing.

Our goal is never to remove a student. We want active learners in the room, and we want every student in the room to be one. Removal is what happens when that has become impossible, not what we are working toward.

A student who has been corrected well should still know they belong here.

"Firmness and gentleness are not opposites. A steady adult is a safe adult."

Reflection Prompt: When I corrected a student today, was I protecting the room, or reacting to being tested?

9. Communication Guidelines

Our words shape our community. Lions Light teachers commit to Brave Communication — honesty wrapped in grace.

Core Principles: Clarity Over Assumption • Curiosity Over Accusation • Grace Over Defense • Story Over Statement

When conflict arises: speak privately, listen to understand, and seek reconciliation before resolution.

"Words can either build bridges or walls. Choose to build."

10. Lesson Planning & Facilitation

Every lesson should flow from **Faith → Learning → Reflection**.

Structure: Faith (connect with Scripture) • Learning (active participation) • Reflection (gratitude or journaling)

Keep lessons interactive, hands-on, and collaborative. Encourage students to connect faith to real-world observations.

Example: After a biology experiment, ask — "What part of God's wisdom do we see in this process?"

11. Student Growth & Reflection

Lions Light focuses on growth over grades. Learning is measured by curiosity, engagement, and transformation — not scores.

Ways to Track Growth: Journals • Portfolios • Reflections • Observed collaboration

Teacher Reflection Question: Did I help students see more of God's wonder today?

12. Safety & Stewardship

Safety is an act of stewardship — for the children God has entrusted to our care.

Commitments: Maintain supervision • Know emergency plans • Stay attentive to student needs • Lead calmly in uncertainty

"Safety is not just physical — it's spiritual and emotional too."

13. Building Community

Lions Light is a family of faith, not a collection of classes. Our strength lies in connection — among teachers, parents, and students.

Ways to Build Community: Speak encouragement • Share resources • Support events • Collaborate across age levels

"Unity grows wherever gratitude is spoken aloud."

Reflection Prompt: How can I contribute to the spiritual and relational health of this community?

14. Closing Words

At Lions Light Academy, we don't simply teach — we illuminate. Every class, conversation, and act of kindness becomes part of a greater light.

Teach boldly. Lead gently. Love deeply. You are the light that helps their light shine.

Scripture Anchors: Proverbs 25:2 • Colossians 3:17 • Colossians 3:23 • John 1:3–4 • 1 Corinthians 13:1–2
